

Making the cut: Tokyo Olympian Manu Bhaker finished fifth in the women's 25m pistol event at the Asian Shooting Championships 2023 in Changwon, the Republic of Korea and in the process, secured a Paris 2024 Olympic quota for India. GETTY IMAGES

shotgun selection system was designed by coach Russell Mark before the Aussie quit in disgust. The process has stayed intact.

However, rifle coach Deepali is not worried about the selection of the rifle team, owing to a bunch of equally competent shooters.

"The rifle shooters are good, and so I am not worried about who gets selected. Air rifle women—they are all strong. In 3P women, Sift Kaur, Anjum, and Ashi Chouksey are very good," said Deepali.

Deepali, who works quietly with her shooters, tuning them and their equipment for the best performances with careful planning, stressed that the Olympics was a different environment and different situation. And everyone needed to keep an open mind. She pointed out that the shortened current Olympic cycle of three years demanded a different approach in terms of the selection of shooters for the Games, apart from their preparation.

Quite smartly, the NRAI has put a line at the end of all its detailed Olympic selection criteria that the decision of the selection committee will be final and binding.

It will be interesting to see how well the selection of shooters for the Paris Games is done.

As always, Abhinav hit the nail on the head when he said, "The worst selection policy will become the best selection policy if the athletes win medals."

Apart from the number of Olympic quota places, the second point that gives a clear indication of the prowess of the Indian shooters is their performance in the last Asian Games in Hangzhou, China.

The Indian team won a record 22 medals in shooting at the last Asian Games, seven less than the leader,

China. India had seven gold, nine silver, and six bronze medals.

For those who are generally quick to point a finger at the team medals won in such a context and state the obvious that the Olympics does not have such team medals, it would be interesting to have a look at the individual medals won in the Asian Games shooting.

India won 10 individual medals, including two gold through Sift Kaur and Palak Gulia, apart from four silver medals, of which Esha Singh won a silver each in air pistol and sports pistol. In comparison, China won 14 individual medals in the Asian Games, and of course, eight of them were gold.

No matter how many World Cups India tops the medal table for, China is always in a different class at the Olympics and Asian Games.

As in many other disciplines, China is a giant in shooting. In the Asian Games, India won only one mixed event medal, the air pistol silver, through TS Divya and Sarabjot Singh. Indian shooters can win more mixed medals in the Olympics if they are tuned nicely for Paris.

Fortunately, there's ample time remaining for Paris, allowing for careful selection and preparation of shooters, potentially resulting in a memorable Olympic experience.



List of Olympic quota winners



Air rifle

Men: Rudranksh Patil, Arjun Babuta.

Women: Mehuli Ghosh, Tilottama Sen.

Rifle 3-position

Men: Swapnil Kusale, Akhil Sheoran.

Women: Shriyanka Sadangi, Sift Kaur Samra.

Air pistol

Men: Sarabjot Singh, Varun Tomar.

Women: Esha Singh.

Rapid fire pistol

Men: Anish Bhanwala, Vijayveer Sidhu.

Sports pistol

Women: Manu Bhaker, Rhythm Sangwan.

Trap

Men: Bhowneesh Mendiratta.

Women: Rajeshwari Kumari.

Skeet

Men: Anantjeet Singh Naruka.

Women: Raiza Dhillon.